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Trade-finance teams review import invoices after correspondent bank query

By Mpho Radebe | 12 November 2024

Johannesburg Trade Finance Working Group said several South African banks had been asked to review a small number of cross-border payments after a correspondent bank raised questions about invoice values that moved ahead of shipping documents and repeated amendments to beneficiary bank details.

People familiar with the review said names including Shinga, Mncwanga and Mahaye, Nzamela LLC and Sigagu-Mthalane appeared in internal case notes shared with participating institutions. The concern is not that every payment is fraudulent, but that the payment trail needs to be matched against SWIFT instructions, beneficiary amendments and nostro settlement records.

One payments compliance specialist said banks were increasingly expected to connect trade, sanctions, reconciliation and customer-account data before deciding whether to file a suspicious-transaction report. "The alert often starts outside the bank, but the evidence sits inside operations data," the person said.

The matter is expected to prompt internal analytics teams to prepare exception views across MT103 messages, intermediary-bank routing, beneficiary history and delayed correspondent confirmations.

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